

# The Information Daily Briefing — 2026-09-24

---

Coverage window: 23 Sep 2026 09:00 — 24 Sep 2026 07:00 (GMT+8)

## Executive Summary

---

The last 24 hours were defined by **an open price war at the frontier and a scramble to lock down cheaper compute**. Anthropic released Claude Opus 5.5 at 40% lower running cost than its prior top models, and OpenAI cut prices in half with GPT-6 Sol and GPT-6 Luna — on the same day. Microsoft followed with authorised Copilot discounts of 30–50% for large seat commitments. The message from all three: enterprise AI bill shock is now a customer-retention problem, and vendors are trading unit price for volume and usage revenue.

On the supply side, **the labs are trying to own their cost base**. Anthropic is in early talks to lease up to 1GW directly from Apollo-controlled Stream Data Centers, potentially with a Google credit guarantee, to cut its reliance on hyperscaler cloud margins. CoreWeave upsized its convertible to \$4.2bn (2.875% coupon), and Crusoe is shifting up the stack into managed inference (\$65m/yr Thinking Machines Lab contract). Capital is still available to AI infrastructure — but it is getting more structured and more expensive.

**China risk re-priced in Hong Kong.** After The Information reported that China's internet regulator is probing seven Chinese AI developers named in Anthropic's data-routing report, Z.ai fell 12.4%, MiniMax 4% and Alibaba 4.4%; the Hang Seng dipped 1%. At the same time, US VCs (Founders Fund, Khosla) are quietly touring Chinese AI labs, and GM is building a China-free battery supply chain as Beijing cut rare-earth magnet exports to the US by 21% ahead of Xi's Washington visit.

**Net read: constructive on volume, cautious on margin.** Price cuts expand usage but compress gross margin for model vendors and seat-based software. Favour owners of scarce physical inputs (power, guaranteed data centre capacity, optics) and investment-grade credit backers; be careful with China AI equities under regulatory overhang and with seat-based software facing 30–50% discounting.

---

## Top Stories — What / Why / When / Which / How

---

### 1. Frontier price war: Claude Opus 5.5 (–40% cost) and GPT-6 Sol/Luna (–50% price)

- **What.** Anthropic released Claude Opus 5.5, which it says matches or beats its prior most powerful models (Fable 5.1, Mythos 5.1) in coding, reasoning,

business workflows and safety, at 40% lower running cost. OpenAI launched GPT-6 Sol and GPT-6 Luna, cheaper and faster members of the GPT-6 Astra family, at half the price of GPT-5.6 Sol/Luna, rolling out in ChatGPT Work and Codex.

- **Why it matters.** This is the first release from Anthropic since its CEO led the industry call to slow frontier development — it ships a *cheaper*, not bigger, model, and leads on its own misbehaviour and deception evaluations. Both labs are responding to enterprise pushback on AI costs, which is increasingly the gating factor on adoption (see yesterday's Zip data and Copilot bill-shock examples).
- **When.** Both announced Tuesday 22 Sep 2026 (US time).
- **Which names.** Anthropic, OpenAI; indirectly Microsoft, Alphabet, Amazon (distribution and cloud), and AI application vendors whose COGS fall.
- **How to act.** Lower token prices are deflationary for model vendors' revenue per unit but positive for usage volume and for application-layer gross margins. Watch whether compute demand (tokens served) rises faster than price falls — the key test for the infra trade.
- **Links.** [Anthropic releases cheaper model](#) · [OpenAI announces cheaper GPT-6 family models](#)

## 2. Anthropic in talks to lease up to 1GW from Apollo-controlled Stream Data Centers

- **What.** Anthropic is in early talks to become a direct tenant of Stream Data Centers (majority-owned by Apollo Global Management) for up to 1GW of capacity, likely filled with Broadcom/Google-designed TPUs and possibly Nvidia GPUs. Anthropic has discussed Google providing a credit guarantee for the project.
- **Why it matters.** Anthropic currently depends on Amazon, Google and SpaceX for compute. Direct leases strip out cloud margin and give it control over the facilities that train and serve Claude. A Google guarantee would make this an investment-grade-backed structure — exactly the kind of credit enhancement the market is now demanding after unguaranteed deals (e.g. Zenith Arc) repriced sharply.
- **When.** Reported 22 Sep 2026; early-stage talks, no signed deal.
- **Which names.** Anthropic, Apollo Global Management (APO), Stream Data Centers, Alphabet/Google (GOOGL), Broadcom (AVGO), Nvidia (NVDA); prior lessors Hut 8 (HUT), TeraWulf (WULF).
- **How to act.** Positive read-through for Broadcom's TPU volumes and for Apollo's digital infrastructure platform. Mildly negative for the cloud-margin share hyperscalers capture on Anthropic spend over time. The Google guarantee is the detail to watch.
- **Links.** [Exclusive: Anthropic in Talks to Cement Control Over More Data Centers](#) · [Briefing](#)

### 3. Microsoft authorises 30–50% Copilot discounts alongside its AI “super app”

- **What.** Microsoft told sales staff it will allow discounts of ~30% for customers with 1,000+ Copilot seats, up to 50% for 10,000+ seats, conditional on committing to usage-based payments for certain features. Starting as soon as October, the discounts coincide with a revamped Copilot “super app” combining coding tools and agent features, some billed on usage. List price starts at \$30/user/month; previous discounts were ~10% for 2,000+ seats.
- **Why it matters.** Microsoft is explicitly converting Copilot from a seat business to a seat-plus-usage business — trading headline ARPU for a usage-revenue tail. It confirms incumbents are paying up to defend against Anthropic and OpenAI going direct to enterprises.
- **When.** Reported 23 Sep 2026; discounts from October 2026.
- **Which names.** Microsoft (MSFT); competitive read-across to Salesforce (CRM), Workday (WDAY), ServiceNow (NOW), Anthropic, OpenAI.
- **How to act.** Expect near-term pressure on Copilot per-seat revenue in FY27 Q2 disclosures; the bull case requires usage revenue to more than offset. Negative read-across for other seat-priced AI add-ons that lack Microsoft’s distribution.
- **Link.** [Exclusive: Microsoft to Boost Copilot Discounts as It Launches AI ‘Super App’](#)

### 4. China’s regulator probe knocks Hong Kong AI stocks — Z.ai –12.4%, Alibaba –4.4%

- **What.** Hong Kong-listed Z.ai (Zhipu) fell 12.4%, MiniMax 4% and Alibaba 4.4%, with the Hang Seng down 1%, after The Information reported that the Cyberspace Administration of China is probing possible data-security breaches. Anthropic had alleged that Chinese developers rerouted sensitive government and military data to Claude to extract its capabilities. The CAC summoned all seven named companies — Alibaba, Z.ai, SenseTime, MiniMax, Xiaomi, DeepSeek and Moonshot — and is focusing on DeepSeek and Moonshot, both preparing IPOs.
- **Why it matters.** Regulatory risk is now priced into listed China AI names, and it could delay the DeepSeek and Moonshot listings. The timing, days before Xi’s Washington visit, adds geopolitical noise.
- **When.** Share move Wednesday 23 Sep 2026.
- **Which names.** Z.ai, MiniMax, Alibaba (9988.HK/BABA), SenseTime (0020.HK), Xiaomi (1810.HK); DeepSeek and Moonshot (private, pre-IPO); Anthropic.
- **How to act.** Treat as an overhang until the CAC outcome is known. Penalties or IPO delays would hit the pure-play model names hardest; Alibaba’s diversified base limits damage.
- **Link.** [Shares of Chinese AI Model Firms Fall After Report of Regulatory Probe](#)

### 5. Meta’s Muse passes 500,000 users in week one

- **What.** Meta’s personal AI agent Muse had 500,000+ users about a week after

its 8 Sep launch, including 250,000+ daily actives and 2m+ prompts, and reached #1 on Apple's App Store (31,000+ ratings). It is available in the US via a standalone app and WhatsApp.

- **Why it matters.** It is early evidence that consumer agents can find demand, reopening the question of whether consumer AI was written off too early. OpenAI is reportedly working on a rival personal assistant; startup Instinct has 100,000+ users. Durability and trust (access to personal accounts and data) remain unproven, and Amazon has already blocked Muse from its shopping site.
- **When.** Internal data reported 23 Sep 2026.
- **Which names.** Meta (META), OpenAI, Instinct (private), SpaceX/xAI (Grok Bot), Amazon (AMZN), Apple (AAPL).
- **How to act.** Supportive of Meta's AI capex narrative going into Q3 earnings; the metric to track is week-4/week-8 retention, not signups. Agent access fights with platforms (Amazon) are the key constraint on monetisation.
- **Link.** [Exclusive: Meta's Muse Surpassed 500,000 Users After First Week](#)

## 6. AI infrastructure financing and business model shifts — CoreWeave upsizes, Crusoe moves up-stack

- **What.** CoreWeave completed an upsized \$4.2bn convertible (vs a \$3bn target): \$3.7bn priced at a 2.875% coupon due 2033 plus a \$500m greenshoe, versus 1.75% on its April 2032 notes. Separately, Crusoe (fresh off a \$3.9bn round) signed a \$65m/yr managed-inference contract with Thinking Machines Lab, running on Nvidia B200s mostly in 1MW "Spark" data centres; its managed-inference product has passed \$100m ARR.
- **Why it matters.** Demand for AI paper is intact but coupons are ~110bp higher than in April — the cost of capital is rising. Crusoe's shift from bare-metal to managed inference (alongside Together, Fireworks, Baseten — all Nvidia-backed) shows neoclouds chasing stickier, higher-margin revenue as raw GPU rental commoditises.
- **When.** CoreWeave closing 22 Sep; Crusoe deal announced 23 Sep 2026.
- **Which names.** CoreWeave (CRWV), Crusoe (private), Thinking Machines Lab (private), Perplexity, Nvidia (NVDA), Together AI, Fireworks, Baseten.
- **How to act.** Convert dilution and rising coupons argue for caution on CRWV equity versus its debt. Managed inference is a positive margin signal for neoclouds that can execute it.
- **Links.** [CoreWeave Completes \\$4.2 Billion Convertible Offering](#) · [AI Agenda: Crusoe and Thinking Machines Lab](#)

## 7. GM fires up a \$900m battery development factory to make China-free LMR cells

- **What.** GM has started making cathodes for lithium manganese-rich (LMR) batteries at its new \$900m Battery Cell Development Center in Warren, Michigan, which can produce hundreds of thousands of test cells a month. GM plans at least one commercial EV on LMR in 2028. It will also develop sodium-

ion cells with Peak Energy for grid storage and AI data centres, using no Chinese materials.

- **Why it matters.** GM's re-entry into EVs, eight months after a \$6bn EV write-down, is built around cheap chemistries China does not control. Timing matters: Beijing cut rare-earth magnet exports to the US by 21% ahead of Xi's visit and restricts exports of its best LFP technology. The sodium-ion angle ties batteries directly to AI data-centre power demand.
- **When.** Cathode production began late August 2026; first LMR EV targeted for 2028.
- **Which names.** General Motors (GM), Ford (F; Fathom pickup, 2028), CATL (300750.SZ), BYD (1211.HK), Tesla (TSLA), Peak Energy (private).
- **How to act.** A long-dated positive for GM's EV optionality and for non-Chinese manganese and nickel supply chains; not a near-term earnings driver. Rare-earth leverage is a live risk for all Western auto and robotics names.
- **Link.** [Exclusive: GM Has Cranked Up a New On-Site Factory to Make a Pioneering Battery](#)

## 8. US VCs quietly tour China's AI labs — Founders Fund, Khosla

- **What.** Three Founders Fund partners (Sean Liu, John Luttig, Joey Krug) visited tech companies in Beijing, Shanghai and Shenzhen last month; Khosla Ventures investors have made similar trips. The goal is learning rather than investing, since US investment in Chinese startups has been cut back sharply.
- **Why it matters.** Chinese labs such as DeepSeek are now seen as setting the pace in parts of AI, especially open-source. A separate Pro analysis of 870,000+ Hugging Face model instances says Chinese open models have rapidly closed the gap with closed models and are winning developer adoption.
- **When.** Trips in August 2026; reported 23 Sep 2026.
- **Which names.** Founders Fund, Khosla Ventures, DeepSeek, Alibaba (Qwen), Moonshot.
- **How to act.** Cheap Chinese open models add to price pressure on closed-model vendors (see story 1). Capital flows remain restricted, so the effect is competitive, not financial.
- **Links.** [Exclusive: Founders Fund, Khosla Ventures Visit China](#) · [Numbers behind Chinese open-source models](#)

## 9. Other notable moves

- **Binance invests \$100m in Circle** at \$80.84/share (5% discount) with a new five-year USDC distribution deal; Circle will pay Binance a monthly fee on USDC held. About \$12bn of the \$75bn USDC supply sits on Binance. CRCL traded at \$94.60. [Link](#)
- **Ligent Technologies** (Qingdao optical transceivers) raised HK\$5.7bn (\$727m) in its Hong Kong IPO; up as much as 19.2% on debut, closing +4.6%. Optics demand remains strong.
- **Private rounds:** Mirendil (ex-Anthropic researchers, self-improving models) in

talks for up to \$1bn at \$5bn; Cyera +\$400m at \$12bn+; Snorkel AI \$350m at \$3.5bn; Micro1 \$100m+ at \$4bn (from ~\$500m a year ago); Heidi \$340m; Verda \$189m at ≥\$1bn; Firecrawl \$75m. AI data and training-data vendors are commanding step-up valuations.

- **OpenAI × Grab** launched a ChatGPT skills programme for ~30,000 drivers, merchants and riders in Singapore, Thailand, Indonesia and the Philippines.  
[Link](#)
- **Anthropic × OpenEvidence** will bring specialised clinical AI to physicians in ~100 low- and middle-income countries.

---

## Market Trend, Development and Sentiment

---

### Trend

**Price deflation at the model layer, cost inflation in capital.** Token prices fell 40–50% in a day and Microsoft authorised 30–50% seat discounts, while CoreWeave paid ~110bp more on its converts than in April. The spread between falling AI output prices and rising AI input costs (debt, power, permits) is the defining tension of Q4.

### Development

- Labs are vertically integrating into data centres (Anthropic–Stream) to control cost.
- Neoclouds are moving up the stack into managed inference (Crusoe, Together, Fireworks, Baseten).
- Consumer agents are showing real early traction (Muse), reviving the consumer AI debate.
- US–China decoupling is widening across AI (CAC probe), batteries (GM LMR) and rare earths (–21% magnet exports).

### Sentiment

**Cautiously constructive, with rising dispersion.** Usage and adoption signals are strong (Muse, price-driven volume), but investors are penalising regulatory risk (Hong Kong AI names), dilutive financing and seat-based pricing. Credit markets remain open but selective, with guarantees becoming the price of admission.

---

## Important Questions Being Asked — and Addressed

---

1. **Will price cuts grow or shrink AI revenue?** *Partly addressed:* both labs frame cuts as optimisation-driven (lower cost to serve), which protects gross

margin. Microsoft is explicitly pairing discounts with usage commitments. The Q4 test is whether tokens served grow more than 2x.

2. **Can labs escape hyperscaler cloud margins?** *Being addressed:* Anthropic's direct Stream lease (plus prior Hut 8 and TeraWulf deals) is the template, but it needs a Google credit guarantee to be financeable.
3. **Is consumer AI dead?** *Challenged:* Muse's 250k DAU in week one and Instinct's traction suggest not. Retention data will settle it.
4. **How do application startups survive the labs moving into their verticals?** *Open:* the options are own models, open-source, or walled-garden data. No clear answer yet (AI Agenda Live theme).
5. **Will the CAC probe derail DeepSeek and Moonshot IPOs?** *Unanswered:* the outcome depends partly on the Trump-Xi summit this week.
6. **Can the West build batteries without China?** *Being tested:* GM's intermediate-scale BCDC is designed to avoid the scale-up failures that killed many US battery startups.

---

## Key Risks

---

| Risk                                        | Signal in last 24h                                    | Who is exposed                                 |
|---------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------|
| AI price deflation outruns volume growth    | –40% (Anthropic),<br>–50% (OpenAI), –30–50% (Copilot) | Model vendors, seat-based SaaS                 |
| Rising cost of AI capital                   | CoreWeave coupon<br>2.875% vs 1.75% in April          | Neoclouds, unrated developers                  |
| China regulatory action                     | CAC probe; Z.ai –12.4%                                | Z.ai, MiniMax, Alibaba, DeepSeek/Moonshot IPOs |
| Rare-earth and supply-chain leverage        | China magnet exports to US –21%                       | Autos, robotics, defence, EVs                  |
| Consumer agent trust and platform blocking  | Amazon blocking Muse; data-access concerns            | Meta, OpenAI, agent startups                   |
| Concentration of guarantees on hyperscalers | Google guarantee discussed for Anthropic lease        | Alphabet balance sheet, lessors                |

---

# Investment Implications — Companies Directly Mentioned

---

*For information only; not investment advice.*

## Constructive

- **Broadcom (AVGO)** — TPU volume upside if Anthropic's Stream lease proceeds; custom silicon benefits as labs chase cost.
- **Apollo (APO)** — Stream Data Centers gains an anchor AI tenant with a possible investment-grade backstop.
- **Meta (META)** — Muse traction supports the AI capex narrative; watch retention.
- **Nvidia (NVDA)** — cheaper tokens drive volume; managed-inference partners (Crusoe, Together, Fireworks, Baseten) broaden demand.
- **General Motors (GM)** — long-dated optionality from a China-free LMR and sodium-ion platform; low near-term impact.

## Cautious

- **Microsoft (MSFT)** — 30-50% Copilot discounts pressure per-seat ARPU; upside depends on usage revenue.
- **CoreWeave (CRWV)** — dilution from converts and a rising coupon; equity more exposed than debt.
- **Z.ai, MiniMax, SenseTime, Alibaba (BABA/9988.HK)** — CAC probe overhang; pure-play model names most at risk.
- **Seat-based SaaS (CRM, WDAY, NOW)** — Microsoft's discounting sets a lower price benchmark for AI add-ons.

## Watch list

- **Alphabet (GOOGL)** — balance-sheet use if it guarantees Anthropic's lease; TPU ecosystem gains.
- **Circle (CRCL)** — Binance deal secures distribution but adds a fee cost; competition from Stripe/Visa/Mastercard-backed OpenUSD.
- **Hut 8 (HUT), TeraWulf (WULF)** — face competition from larger developers for Anthropic leases.
- **Ford (F), CATL, BYD** — the US-China battery contest intensifies into 2028.

---

*Sources: The Information newsletters received 23 Sep 2026 (The Information AM, AI Agenda, The Electric, exclusives). The website itself showed a bot-verification page during this run, so the briefing draws on the full newsletter text in Gmail. Not investment advice.*